houses such as Wadia, Singhania, Kirloskar, Mafatlal, C.K. Birla and M.P. Birla had dropped off the exclusive club. Ratan, by taking a plethora of bold and risky decisions, kept the group in the number one position.

Unsurpassed Growth

In about a decade with Ratan at the helm, the House of Tatas transformed into an integrated body. It became much like a federation, with a unitary bias. And by 2012, nine Tata companies were in the *Fortune* India 500 list. Together, their revenues contributed 4.5 per cent of India's GDP. And in the same year, the aggregate revenue of all Tata companies represented 5.47 per cent of the GDP. The corresponding figure for 1992 was 1.89 per cent. This represented a rise of over 190 per cent in the share of the revenue of Tata companies in India's GDP from 1992–2012—a period of high GDP growth.

Interestingly, in the nearly twenty-two years that Ratan was at the helm, the growth of the Tata group enterprises also dwarfed some of the most fabled and celebrated US companies. But as an Indian entity, neither the group nor its leadership got the recognition they deserved.

General Electric (GE) gained worldwide attention under its legendary CEO Jack Welch, for its transformation and growth. Under him, the multinational grew in a sharp trajectory, catapulting Welch into the cosmos of celebrities. By the time he was ready to hang up his boots, *Fortune* magazine in 1999 declared him as the 'manager of the century' for his business leadership of the corporation.

When Welch took over the reins in 1981, his predecessor likened GE to the '*Queen Mary*, a majestic ocean liner, caught in a storm'. If a similar analogy is applied to the Indian conglomerate, when Ratan took over Tata Sons, the group was like a collection of small but virtually rudderless independent boats, some on the verge of capsizing but steered by legendary captains, moving about at their own pace and doing their own things. By the time he retired, he had transformed Tata Sons into a flotilla of largely formidable companies, moving in a tight formation with its promoter Tata Sons at the centre as the mothership—a sort of task force.

During Welch's watch, 1981–2000, GE's revenue rose from $27 billion to $130 billion, an increase of slightly over 4.8 times or 381 per cent in nineteen years. For the leadership he gave the US giant, he was also dubbed as the 'most celebrated American boss of recent decades' by *The Economist*